

Amphibians

Earth's 5,000 kinds of amphibian are thin-skinned animals and need to stay moist. Most of them breed by laying eggs in freshwater. They usually start life as swimming tadpoles, or larvae, which slowly change shape and move onto land.

Caecilians

These wormlike amphibians live only in the tropics (near the equator). They have no legs and many spend all their lives in the soil.



Typical caecilians have a cylindrical body divided into rings, with a wedge-shaped snout used for burrowing.

Salamanders and newts

Most of the animals in this group are called salamanders. Some live on land, but most breed in water. Newts are members of just one family.



The Eastern newt starts life in water as a tadpolelike larva. It then spends 1–4 years as a bright-red juvenile, before transforming again into an aquatic adult.



A male crested newt's conspicuous crest develops only when adults return to water to breed.



Mole salamander larvae have feathery gills and some can breed without transforming into land-dwelling adults.



Lungless salamanders breathe through their skin and the lining of their mouths. Many live entirely on land.



The fire salamander's colors warn predators that it is toxic.

Frogs and toads

Unlike other amphibians, adult frogs and toads do not have tails. Their hind legs are often larger than the front pair, and they can have webbed feet or separate toes. Experts are not in agreement on which of these animals are called frogs and which are toads. Most frogs and toads breed in water, although some lay their eggs in trees, leaving their tadpoles to drop into pools and streams.



Amazonian horned frogs have thickset, camouflaged bodies, large mouths, and a prominent horn above each eye.



Poison dart frogs are small, highly toxic rain forest amphibians that often have conspicuous warning colors.



Flying frogs live in rain forests. Their large, webbed feet allow them to parachute from tree to tree.



Rain frogs shelter underground during the dry season, coming to the surface after rain to eat insects.